To the Chair and Committee members of Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters

Preface

I live in Deans Marsh Victoria, currently in the seat of Wannon, held by [redacted] MP. Deans Marsh is a small rural community; its community hall – a former Mechanics Institute opened in 1887 – has operated as a polling place since before Federation. I have volunteered here regularly for elections – state federal and referendum.

I am very pleased to report to the Committee that election day 2025 played out in its usual friendly, cruisy way. The volunteers from [redacted], [redacted], [redacted] and [redacted] were all locals: we chatted, handed out for each other if needed, shared cake and lollies, and then all scrutineered together.

Although it was a long day [I was there from 6.30am to 7.45pm], it was a lovely Deans Marsh sort of day, as it has always been in my experience.

I am sad to say that the 2025 Campaign across Wannon was not like that.

Introduction

This submission is made to the Committee by me personally. It is not a submission on behalf of the Voices of Wannon: it has made its own separate submission.

I am a 'reluctant' resident of Wannon – reluctant in the sense that I was appalled to find we had been redistributed before the 2022 election out of Corangamite, where I had helped to campaign against the incumbent, and defeated the [redacted] candidate in 2019. To find myself with the [redacted] filled me with dismay.

In late 2021 therefore I was delighted to learn that a [redacted] candidate was being sought for Wannon by the Voices of Wannon [VOW].

Since 2013 I had watched, and admired very much, what has been happening in Indi with the Voices for Indi and its original candidate, the wonderful [redacted] and the movement she, her successor [redacted], and their supporters have since built both in Indi, and elsewhere across Australia.

I joined the Voices of Wannon late in 2021 and was active in volunteering for the [redacted] campaign in the 2022. I focussed my volunteering especially on talking to voters in the eastern parts of Wannon, then newly part of the electorate. Part of that volunteering was informing the freshly-redistributed Wannon voters about their 'new' MP [redacted], and then introducing them to [redacted] who had run on his own in 2019 and gained 10% of the vote in the 'old' version of Wannon. VOW endorsed him as the candidate in January 2022, and again in 2025.

VOW's goal in 2022 was to make Wannon marginal and we did. More information about VOW can be found here [redacted]

VOW members were again active during the 2025 federal election campaign, indeed for this year's election, we were active from August 2024 until May 3 2025. I was one of the 1000 volunteers, actively participating in a wide range of activities right across the electorate of Wannon, again in support of the [redacted] candidate [redacted].

VOW volunteers all signed a Code of Conduct. Another was required to be signed by all [redacted] campaign team volunteers. Both required positive campaigning and friendly personal communications at all times. However, as I will explain, others active in the campaign did not all behave in these ways.

My submission to your inquiry sets out some observations made during the 2025 federal election campaign which are of concern. It also asks a range of questions about your Inquiry and its scope and depth.

1. **In relation to Terms of Reference 1,2,3,**

My experience during the campaign relate directly to one, two or three of the Terms of Reference in integrated ways. The first three of your terms of reference are set out below:

That the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters inquire into and report on all aspects of the conduct of the 2025 federal election and related matters, including consideration of the following:

- assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials;
- potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;
- the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements; .....

In order to set the tone for what I saw and experienced as a hostile vicious campaign, see below the following two pages which merely two examples of the flurry of materials which were comprehensively mailed[1] and handed out to voters in Wannon by the [redacted] Party of Australia and its associated organisations.

As you will see, these documents, which could be considered defamatory in any other context, are authorised formally by the [redacted] Parry of Australia.

[1] At taxpayers' expense.

They are indicative of the hostile vicious content and tone [and of expensive production values] of all the materials put out by the [redacted] before and during the 2025 election campaign. In my experience no other candidate or volunteer treated others in such ways.

Complaints to AEC about the misrepresentation and malice contained within these flyers and others, did not provide a remedy, due to the limitations of the rules, regulations and legislation under which the AEC operated.

These regulations and/or laws must be changed to take into account the new and poisonous tactics of the [redacted] and its associated entities.

Voting Centre
Alex Dyson
POLITICIANS VOTE:
73%
with
CANDIDATE

"2

Essentially, I see that the first three Terms of Reference are seeking to understand whether current provisions and laws and regulations relating to the design, regulation and maintenance of voter, volunteer and Australian Electoral Commission staff behaviour and security at pre-polling and polling places in Australia and internationally, are fit for purpose, or need to be revised and changed.

For me the 2025 election campaign in Wannon has demonstrated that significant reform is required to:

- **Ensure the safety of voters, volunteers and AEC staff at polling booths,**

On multiple occasions at the Colac pre-polling place when I was on shift, Plymouth Brethren groups of youngish men monstered, harassed and jeered at both other pollical volunteers and Colac voters outside the polling place.

This created an unpleasant atmosphere in 2025, where in all previous campaigns [2022 and before] pre-polling was friendly pleasant and collegiate – we all chatted to each other and shared umbrellas and lollies. No more.

Instead, there was a distinct Them and Us vibe where volunteers from all other groups and voters looked on in bewilderment, and in some cases fear, as the huddle of Brethren launched themselves on to voters as they approached the polling place. All attempted friendly overtures to the 'Brethren Bros' from all other parties' volunteers were rebuffed rudely.

- **Require truth in all electoral materials being distributed by everyone**

See the examples of large [redacted] signs above – everyone in Wannon received multiples of these in the mail, and they were also corflutes, signs, and billboards all over Wannon.

- **Require real time disclosure of all electoral related donations AND expenses by all candidates**

[redacted] disclosed all donations above those of a very small amount on his website which was updated on a weekly basis, as I understand it. ALL candidates should be required to so this – in law.

[2] The text and images in these large signs also formed a series of full-colour mail out leaflets which were received by all Wannon households. They contain false and misleading information and were authorised by the [redacted] Party and thus to [redacted] Campaign materials like these - of a deceptive and malicious nature - of which there was a very large amount distributed in Wannon, were not linked to any other candidate or party standing for election.

AEC: change is needed to allow it to do its job.
Like almost all Australians, I have the highest respect for the AEC and believe it needs the resources – legislative and financial – necessary to continue to perform the job it was designed to do. [see 1.1 and 1.2 below]

I believe strongly that the Committee should request **senior management of AEC should testify** at your hearings so Committee members can learn what resources the AEC needs to continue to do the excellent job it does, in this new hostile electoral environment.

1.1 New Regulations and Legislation: While this may prove very difficult, the Committee could consider making recommendations about the creation of new regulations relating to size and scope of electoral advertising and other electoral materials
e.g. even HTV are no longer A5 but should be limited to that size, I think.

Size does matter and just because some can afford/boast larger ones, does not reflect superiority.

Corflutes size and designated allocated spaces for their erection could perhaps also be regulated.

Another way of addressing the problem may be to limit and restrict tightly the amount of money any **and all** candidates can spend on election campaigns, and on what each spends it on, and that this should be revealed in real time by each candidate and MP as the [redacted] candidates do.

I note that, as I understand the 2024 partial electoral 'reforms', while the changes will severely limit SOME BUT NOT ALL candidates' fund-raising capacities, the [redacted] and the [redacted] retain unlimited access to their external funding bodies. I view the provisions which allow these profound inequalities as travesties of democracy and seeks their repeal. [see also 3. below]

1.2 The best way, of course, to address some of the problems listed here would be properly **legislate for truth in political advertising** as proposed by [redacted] MPs and others.
As one of my colleague volunteers put it "There is no place in democracy for lies." Currently, however, there is such space. That needs to change.

The current government's failure to act on truth in political advertising when it commands such a majority in the House, and could pass it in the Senate with the support of the [redacted] and Crossbench, reveals either its abject cowardice, or the unprincipled cooperation with the [redacted] by the [redacted]

I would like to ask the [redacted], **and** [redacted] **in particular**, whether they are content to govern in a system which allows voters to be intimidated as Wannon voters

and the volunteers from other political parties and organisations were during the 2025 federal election campaign across Australia?

Perhaps they too should testify before the Committee members?

I would like to see that.

We can all see – right now in the US - where such vile, intimidatory behaviour is leading, and has led: legislative 'permission' legitimises intimidation and the 2024 'reforms' seem to me to provide such 'permission'.

I believe that the blatant partiality of the 2024 'electoral reforms' acts to grant such 'legislative permission'. This will allow for the continued intimidation of voters by the [redacted] and its related organisations. I am surprised [redacted] wants that for his legacy… or am I?

Seeking direct testimony from [redacted]
In addition to seeking the views of the AEC about necessary reforms in the changed electoral environment, and of the [redacted] and [redacted], I ask that the Committee require the testimony in person before the Committee of [redacted]

In my view [redacted] needs to explain himself in person to the Committee and to the people of Wannon.

On election day [redacted] was reported on page 2 of the [redacted] as saying 'it had been a really positive campaign'.

This statement is either a lie or demonstrates [redacted]'s profound cogitative dissonance.[3]

Given that [redacted] either sought himself, or allowed [redacted] to supply, Plymouth Brethren personnel to his campaign, as well as publishing via his mailed-out flyers, repeatedly to everyone, a series of deliberate lies about [redacted], I suggest [redacted] be asked the following questions:

- How does [redacted] define 'a really positive campaign'?
- How was it that [redacted] came to recruit the Plymouth Brethren and other right-wing organisations to participate in his campaign in Wannon?
- Did Advance and or the Plymouth Brethren offer their services to him?
- Did [redacted] engineer that participation, or did [redacted]?

[3] Cognitive dissonance is a psychological phenomenon that occurs when a person holds two contradictory beliefs at the same time

- Did [redacted] require the participation of these external organisations in Wannon, or was it [redacted]'s own initiative?

- Was each external organisation paid for their 'assistance', how much were they paid, and by whom?

- Did [redacted] pay them from his own electoral funds OR was there one large payment from the [redacted] Party directly or via the Cormack Foundation?

In my view these are all serious questions which deserve answers on the public record. Many people in Wannon would like to know the answers.

To me, the involvement of, and the behaviour of these 'additional parties' - especially if it was for a fee and/or for some promise of *quid pro quo* in the future – amounts to electoral malpractice, and penalties should result. If current electoral law does not see this behaviour as being subject to penalties, it should. That needs to change.

2. **In relation to T of R 4:**

the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.

This term of reference seems perhaps to relate to the use of digital media in electioneering? If that is its intent, then yes new regulation is needed: see the comments about the need for new AEC powers above.

Australian regulation of the algorithms used by social media companies [and their effective taxation] is required, in relation to electoral matters in particular and at least, but in my opinion much more broadly.

3. **In relation to T of R 5**

   The Special Minister of State has also asked the Committee to consider the interaction with the following:

- *the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election;*

I note that this Term of Reference 5 and those below, which [redacted] 'has asked the Committee [and therefore all Australians] to consider' are huge questions – broad and deep in scope.

In relation to T of R 5, it seems to me this request to 'consider in the interaction with' does not in any way do justice, or give the necessary weight to, the need to understand the potentially undemocratic and completely unfair effects of some provisions of the '*the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament'*. [see also my comments at 1.1 above]

Given that many of the provisions of '*the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament*' do not come into effect until the next federal election due in 2028, I ask: how is it even possible to consider them in context?

I believe that this Term of Reference requires a separate and comprehensive Inquiry of its own, given that several of the provisions in those reforms create an unfair and unequal playing field for all seeking election to parliament EXCEPT candidates from the [redacted] and [redacted].

Given the selective benefits provided by these provisions, it is no surprise that it was those same parties who worked together to pass the legislation.

That fact brings shame on them all.

It would be useful however for such 'bi-partisanship' to be repeated in relation to both T of R 6 *'ongoing threats'* and 7 *'the composition of Parliament as a whole…'*.
I note however that given the government's large majority in the House and the real possibility of the government co-operating with [redacted] and the Crossbench MPs in the Senate, such 'major' party cooperation, while it can be desirable, is not actually required.

Any statement by the current government that such bipartisanship is 'needed' to prevent later repeal is simply nonsense – in fact such statements are deliberately manufactured excuses for cowardice by the [redacted].[4] If this last statement seems harsh, consider that the current [redacted] was leader of government business in the House during the [redacted] when some 400 pieces of legislation were passed – often to the deep chagrin of the other potential 'party of government'. [redacted] seemed not to care about potential 'later repeal' then; and in any event as we have all seen many times, [redacted] Party agreement on one day, does not guarantee it on the next.

4. In relation to T of R 6

- *reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic; and*

In my experience in Wannon, the most serious import from 'foreign' sources was the aggressive and hostile tone and behaviour of [redacted][5] and his extended campaign team. Their tactics echoed those of Trump directly and are thus 'imported foreign threats'.

I think that this Term of Reference also requires a separate and comprehensive Inquiry of its own, involving serious examination of submissions from the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, and all security agencies. This T of R seems to me to overlap and

---

[4] [redacted]

[5] [redacted]

integrate with T of R 4, the potential for digital interference in our electoral processes, and is too important to be somehow treated incidentally as the current Terms of Reference imply.

5. **In relation to T of R 7**

- *the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.*

Unfortunately, again this Term of Reference is far too important to be apparently an afterthought or mere add-on.

I note that while state governments have been able to do this without fuss, the Australian Constitution requires a referendum to change the parliamentary terms for reform to be achieved for the federal parliament. Given recent despicable tactics in the most referendum and postal survey by the [redacted], the necessary bipartisanship by the largest parties seems unlikely.

This is hugely to be regretted.

Although it was commented recently to me by a Wannon voter: “It's not rocket science it just needs bipartisan good will to achieve this outcome.”

Unfortunately, as Professor Anne Twomey advises, it IS somewhat ‘rocket science-y’. She suggests a four-year fixed term for both House and Senate might work IF the reserve powers were dealt with effectively by a Constitutional Convention AND when there was committed and honoured support for such a referendum from both the larger parties/coalitions[6]

I note the calls by some for what could be more effective representation by reducing the size of the population allocated to each federal electorate. While I can see some sense in having the AEC reduce and redistribute electoral boundaries to include say 100,000 voters, I also see that the amount of work for the AEC, the likely resulting political disruption, and the increased cost of so many more federal MPs may mean any government finds these ideas unpalatable.[7]

That fact should not prevent the [redacted] government from considering it very seriously.

I also believe that **the pre-polling period of two weeks is too long** and could be reduced to one week. People unable to vote in that period or on polling day can do a postal vote. The **postal voting timeframe should be expanded to allow more time**, and should operate ONLY via the AEC: never via sitting MPs’ electorate offices. A longer postal voting period would help those unable to use overseas polling places.

---

[6] .See https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-pJywiihapA
[7] See https://www.abc.net.au/news/2025-10-03/grattan-on-friday-case-for-more-politicians/105778642

5.1 Conclusion and a concern

In conclusion I thank the Australian Parliament for the opportunity to make it aware of the newly hostile atmosphere during the 2025 federal election campaign in Wannon. This was a most unwelcome development when compared to the 2022 campaign here.

It is clear to me that

- **one person** [redacted]
- **his party - the** [redacted] **and**
- **his associates – Advance and others and the Plymouth Brethren 'congregation' – were those responsible for creating the hostile tone of the Wannon campaign, although it is certainly true that some of the same organisations contributed to the same negative atmosphere elsewhere around Australia**.

While [redacted] was not successful in Wannon, I was absolutely thrilled to see that the Australian electorate voted to reject resoundingly the aggressive and hostile approach to democracy imported from the US, and adopted by the [redacted] in many places.

A final concern

Several of the Terms of Reference of this Inquiry are very broad indeed, and proper examination of them needs to be comprehensive. I am far from sure that this current Inquiry is the best place for that broad and deep evaluation. I hope – profoundly – that their inclusion here is not just a sly attempt by [redacted] to 'get issues' 'off the table', when most of them require long and serious analysis.

Dr Deb Campbell
Deans Marsh
[redacted]